Observation Notes - Blake Gideon - February 2024

E Block CSP1 Class

Wednesday, February 21, 2024

Blake's Guiding Questions:

- Am I doing a good job paying attention and checking in with all students? (Versus getting tied up with squeaky wheels)
- Am I delivering the instructions clearly to students so students can get working promptly?
- How am I doing with delivering encouragement while students are working?

Detailed Observation Notes

Before Class Starts:

Students coming in, Blake directs to assigned seats.
Students sitting in rows facing North board, rows of 5 5 5.

Student Numbers at Start of Class:
1 2 3 4 5
6 7 8 9 10
11 12 13 14 15
11 = TA

Groups Later:
1 2 3
4 5
6 7

Agenda on East board

- Python code-along
- Team up + Debug
- Complete google doc questions
- Bonus question

Class Begins:

1:35	BG asks students to put phones away. Does question of the day, going through all students. During, some students are chatting with each other. BG reminds them to put phones away. 3 students are on their computers.
1:38	BG introduces new "exciting topic" - Python. Tells students some ways language is used in the world. Compares to Scratch where we could snap code together, but now we have to type. Overviews what students will make with Python.
1:39	BG asks students to install Mu Editor, writes URL on East board. Several students are playing games while it downloads, several are messaging others. BG at computer at front of room walks through what the download should look like, what to click.

1:42	BG walks around room, checking what is installed and what students are doing. One student had left room during instructions, so BG catches that student up. 3 students ask what mode to put the Mu Editor in (Python 3)
1:44	BG reminds to put phones away. Introduces code along. 2-3 students are still waiting for install as BG starts the code along. 1 more student asks what mode to put MU Editor in. BG instructs students “We’re going to do a code along and then you’re going to debug and problem solve what the issue is.” BG begins typing on the board, narrating each word and character being typed. Narrates what happens when you click play, the save window, saving, and the window that pops up once it runs. The program runs, BG explains “This is our program, our output here. You can expand this window” 1 student is still waiting on download. 1 student helps neighbor with installation.
1:48	BG pivots “How about this… write 2 more print statements. Write 2 more pieces of printed information” BG walks around the room. 1 student needs help with loaner computer. Blake checks in with students 1, 5, 10, 12, 15 during this time.
1:50	BG gets attention back to front of room “just bear with me, I’m going to type out a few lines of code. I want you to code along with me” BG narrates what he is typing, narrating each character typed on the first line. Slightly less narration on the second line. Once done typing, “I’ll also do this, let me stop and rerun it” and BG points out what printed at the bottom. BG gives next instruction “I want you to add comments above all 3 of these lines to say what they do. Once you write the code and see it execute. If you do that, write a comment. You’ll start with this name and write what the code does.” Student 12 announces an error, TA is next to student and helps a bit. BG checks in, thanks TA. BG walks behind back row, points out an error in Student 15s code. Talks with S10 about an error. Walks behind second row. Talks with S7 about an error, asks “What did you write on that line?” Talks with S6 to remind them of instructions, repeating them “on each of these lines, you’re going to write what it does.” Talks with S1 asking “is this working?” and then points to an error on computer. BG goes back to front of room. S15 has hand raised. S14 and 7 are doing things other than code.
1:56	BG gives next instruction “I’m going to have everyone go to Canvas now. You’re going to be doing a similar thing. Running the code and then annotating above it by making a code comment.” Explains to students where to look on Canvas to find the code and has them “copy lines 33 and below into your program.” A student is confused, asking if they should delete what is there or start over, and BG tells them to decide with their partner.
1:58	BG counts off students to make 7 random groups. There’s confusion about groups, BG says “oh my god” as students don’t remember their numbers. They eventually figure out some groups to sit down. Student asks “Are both of us doing this or one of us?” BG says “all of us are doing this together” and tries to clarify. BG starts to go around to speak with individual groups and explain instructions. Another student up front announces “Wait what are we doing”

	Group 3 student says “Mr Gideon Mr Gideon” and raises hand BG asks “just a minute” while finishing up with current students, encouraging them to run the code to help explain. Group 6 has a question about a particular line of code, BG talks with one member of group about it. One student in Group 7 says “I don’t know what I’m doing” so BG points to a line of code and then reminds them of instructions to explain what that line does. BG stays with group 7, as they are wondering “where’s the error? I thought it was going to say error” and BG says they’ll get there if they start with instructions. Group 4 and 3 try to ask questions, BG asks them to pause and goes up front.
2:04	BG regroups class “Can everyone 45 their computer really quick? I forgot to tell you something. You can actually type down here” and continues to explain how to interact with program. Tells students to keep going. Group 5 asks “Do we have to fix the code?” BG goes over to help, but clarifies instructions. “Above every line, you need to write a comment about what the code does, what it does when it runs” Groups 1 2 4 are talking together, saying “I don’t know why it doesn’t work” and are discussing a commented out line. One student tries to explain “I think we are supposed to uncomment it out”. Group 1 raises hand. Group 3 says they are finished. BG asks “did you notice anything wrong with the code?” They point out something, but BG says that should work. Then directs them to the math section. BG explains that they should go to Canvas, go to modules, and find some resources. He says they can “find something on the first 2 pages.” BG checks in with Group 2. Goes to Group 1. Answers Group 1’s question about the commented out variable by pointing and referencing things on the front board. Group 5 and 6 have questions. BG talks to G6, who says they are finished. BG wonders whether they fixed a bug, and they didn’t. He again to this group directs them to Canvas and the resource to use. G5 has the same question. BG points them to Canvas and the resource. BG asks a student in G3 what they were working on, they say they were messaging a friend. BG approaches G3, telling them more specifically what section of the resource to look on, gives them “a bigger hint” BG checks with G2, who also didn’t fix the bug. BG points them to the resource and where to look on Canvas.
2:14	BG regroups class, “alright so most people have started to encounter a bug.” BG references part 3 and runs the code, to “see what the bug is.” After demonstrating the bug, BG says “This is something brand new. You’re going to get information about it by going to Canvas and finding the resource.” BG points out the doc, to look in the first pages. G3 says they found the error. BG checks in and they’ve found part of it. G1 raises hand. BG goes over. Students wonder about whether something is a conditional and BG explains why it’s not.

	G4 is having a conflict about who should look at what code. BG reminds "take it easy, we are working as a team here." BG redirects them to the resources on Canvas and tells them to look at page 2. "Read the whole section and see if it leads to a clue. Don't try anything until you read the whole thing." BG checks with G6, who says they "tried something but it wouldn't work." BG points at the section in the resource, pointing to float and int. BG defines what int and float are, explaining the difference. G4 calls the TA over, the TA goes to help them. BG checks with G7, who is looking at the wrong section and adding functions. BG tells them to remove all that stuff, points to where to focus and asks them to read the section.
2:19	BG walks up front, asking "did I have a question up here?" BG checks in with G3, then G1 about the float and the input. G2 is stuck at this time. Then BG talks with G2 about the float as well. BG checks in with G3 again, asking "what do you think of Python so far?... It's harder but it's rewarding." G5 is confused, saying they read the document but don't know what to do. BG instructs "We have 3 minutes left. You're going to want to stay away from the def stuff and focus on the user input section." They say they read it, so BG asks them to explain what it was about. G7 asks for help, but BG is still finishing with Group 5. Groups 2, 4, and 6 are not working on assignment now.
2:25	BG speaks aloud to the class, saying "there are some questions that are next up that are in the assignment." Group 7 and 4 have hands up. BG is still talking with G5. Students start talking more, packing up. BG says "that's all the time we have today, good work!" Several students ask "do we need to submit this?" and "do we need to turn this in"
2:26	Students are packing up. BG reminds "you're going to need to save this, because we'll need this next time"

My Overall Questions and Reflections

Successes:

- Time was split effectively between code-along working as a class, then independent work, then group work. Students had opportunities to work in different ways throughout the class, keeping them mostly engaged.
- Moving into groups energizes students, is a good break.
- Blake checked in with all students at various points, everyone got some content time. Blake also walked throughout the room pretty evenly to share attention.
- Blake pivoted from original plan when it seemed like it was going to take too long and rolled with the change to give students more "hands on" time.

Questions & Challenges:
- Blake had to repeat instructions several times to different students. Both instructions about the commenting the code and then later instructions about the resources available. How could those instructions be made clearer to students and more accessible?
- Students could rely on their partner more during pair work to answer questions, rather than immediately going to Blake with a question. Random groups vs. student choice groups can be tricky, so how to incentivize students to really collaborate with their partner?
- Students work at different paces, so the end of the class was a bit rushed and students were ending in different places without a real wrapup. What routines can be put in place to wrap up class more effectively?

Ideas:
- Prepare a more detailed agenda or instructions. Have that visible to students to point towards when they are confused
- When you pivot on the fly, have students rely on a partner to give you a few minutes to prepare instructions. Write on board or project them.
- Incorporate routines for the end of class. Teacher summarizes or asks students to summarize. Has students share 1 thing they learned, either aloud or with partner. Has students share 1 question. Exit ticket type check-ins?

Blakes A Block Prototyping & Innovation Class
Tuesday, February 6, 2024

Observation Notes:
** These notes are messier, sorry!*

Students sitting all in a line, 6 students
Goal written on board - “Complete 1-2 screens of your prototype”

Students have their proposals written on paper, are working on starting
Blake asking each student what their first screens are that they are making
Student clarifies what the goal is
Some students talking with each other about what to start on
“It’s already looking good, good work”
One student writing on the board, blake stops by and student talks about what they are adding
“I’m going to look back a the feedback I gave you to refresh my mind”
One student needs to rewrite their work because it’s too messy
One student has a question about a feature of how to do something with the app, so Blake looks up a video to find it

Goes back to a student to revisit their plan from last time, asks for more information about somethinng that “was a really good idea” and it wasn’t incorporated anywhere into the plan. Student starts drawing on the board how that idea will work.
Asks a student what screen they are working on, says their logo looks “really cool”
Takes a student’s paper for feedback but then student wants it back, give me at the end of class. Going back and forth about taking pictures or uploading it or giving back.
12:00
Student standing at board is just standing.
Blake looks in at student’s computers. Has his computer open, walks from behind.
Student is still working on their logo.
“Let’s say, in the next 10 minutes or so, you have started on your app. You can always go back to your logo.”
Student on board calls over.
Student asks other students “does anyone remember how to make things scrollable? two students answer”
Then talking about weekend plans and some cheer competition. Other students join in, now everyone (except for student on board) is talking about cheer competitions.
Student on board “is that too much”? Blake says “it’s not about the numbers.”
12:05
Still working on logo, looking for images.
Goal is on the side board, off to side of all students. In front of them is blank.
Question: have you talked about fair use of images? Fonts? Logos?
Blake gives student advice on what screens to start with, picking two. Talking about how this is going to take a couple weeks to get a lot of polish.
12:10
Student says “I have 2 slides done”. Blake says “wow you’re fast.” Talking about the screens, what’s done so far. Blake says “great, awesome work!”
Checking with each student, what screen are you working on, “nice work”
Student wondering about adjusting dimensions. Go back and select device of “pro max” to get a wider device window. “You should be able to do custom dimensions, it’s about the proportions, width to height”
Question: have you talked about resizing, working on different devices? Phone only? Have you talked about accessibility?
12:12
Blake says “About 25 minutes left”
Student asks “Do you like this?” Blake says “Oh yeah, that is cool!”
Students working quietly, Blake walks around. Sits up front to review student work.
12:16
Asks student “did you read the feedback? did you make any changes?”
Question: I wonder if there is a more strategic way to have them all review their feedback to make sure they did it.
Asking student about what the purpose of a screen is, that is has 2 different features for if you are or aren’t on a trip. Blake says “I’d break this up into two screens” and makes a suggestion. Then student talks about what they had in mind and how it would work for both, it’s like a homepage with everything. Since they are different, Blake says he needs to sketch them out.
12:19
Student asks “is this okay, is this too simple? do you like this?”
Walking around, says to another student “you should actually make usernames for this so it’s a prototype that we can use.”

Then that student has a question about scrolling, why it's not working how they wanted. Trying to help student troubleshoot why the scrolling isn't working. Ungroup the text boxes. Tells the student to click on one, points at the screen.
Another student says "I'm going to cry, I don't know how to insert a bullet point" Blake shares the shortcut.
Student from board from earlier says they've got some stuff. Wants Blake to look at it. Laughing about using other people's pictures from a previous project.
Girl in middle hasn't talked for a while.
12:25
Checks back in with student "did you get it to scroll" student shows, "it's very rough, that's fine"
Student from earlier has question again about if I should use 2 photos or 1. Suggestion of using a stock photo.
12:28
"We only have 7 minutes left, wow time flies"
"I wish you would have told me that before, I'm telling you now"
Question: do they know how realistic they are going for?
Says to girl who has been quiet "that's really good"
Student has question about masking/cropping to get an image. Blake looks up on his computer, then goes back to help that student more with figuring out the image crop.
12:31
Students showing Blake what they added.
Talking about an icon. Blake says "more traditionally they'd use an icon with multiple people"
Question: Is there a way they can learn about what happens "more traditionally?" Have you talked about this? Maybe looking at design guidelines or something…
Blake checks in on girl at end "hows yours?"
A student is working on other class stuff.
12:33
"we have 2 minutes left. Make sure you're saved up. Make sure you finish those 2 remaining videos about the horizontal scroll area cause I'm going to look at those"
Students do not look up during this announcement, still clicking.
Students want Blake to take a look at those horizontal scroll snapping, 2 ask for feedback.
12:35
"Alright, that's all the time we've got. Alright everyone, you guys are moving pretty quickly"

Questions & Ideas

- You asked several students if they'd read their feedback. Was there or will there be built in time, assignment, structure for responding to feedback? How to hold them accountable to engaging with feedback (an everpresent issue with students…)
- Some students were asking "is this good enough" or "how much do I need to have done" type questions.
    - Do they have a rubric of what they're working towards and how it will be assessed?
    - Maybe have them make a timeline, schedule, or plan for themselves so they know what to do next at any point?
- Have they looked at the comparables for their app, meaning looked for similar apps that already exist? Will they at some point?

- Topics you might consider to cover?
    - Copyrighted images & fair use
        - Share databases of copyright free images
            - and/or note about crediting sources
        - Using this for purely educational use vs. using in a portfolio some day
    - Standard or “traditional” ways of designing things
        - Apple Human Interface Guidelines
        - Google Material Design
    - Accessibility?
        - W3C Web Accessibility Standards WCAG
        - Apple, Google and others have Accessibility guidelines